Thrive.

Institute of Wellness & Development

AI Productivity & Prompt Engineering

A friendly, practical guide for everyone — no technical background needed

● EASY	●● INTERMEDIATE	●●● ADVANCED
Use it today. No tech background. Start here.	Templates, files, workflows & habits.	Systems, code, data, agents & evaluation.

■ **Key idea**
AI is not the skill. The real skill is knowing **what to ask**, **which tool to pick**, **how to describe the job clearly**, and **when to double-check the answer**.

Workshop Edition · Beginner → Advanced

Workshop date: add here

How to use this guide

Every topic is marked Easy, Intermediate or Advanced so you always know where to start. You do not need to read everything. Pick the path that matches your role and skip ahead when something feels familiar.

You are…	Start at	First quick win
Student or learner	Easy → Intermediate	Turn one lecture PDF into a quiz
Teacher or trainer	Easy → Intermediate	Make a 10-slide lesson + quiz
Office / business pro	Easy → Intermediate	Turn a meeting transcript into notes & follow-up
Wellness / coaching	Easy → Intermediate	Draft client handouts (always review)
Entrepreneur / freelancer	Intermediate	Automate enquiry replies with approval
Marketer / content creator	Easy → Intermediate	Turn one long piece into a week of posts
Researcher / analyst	Intermediate → Advanced	Deep research + check every source
Manager / leader	Intermediate	Pick 3 repeated tasks & measure time saved
Developer / data pro	Intermediate → Advanced	Debug a real bug, then add a test

■ **Try this**
Open this guide, pick one task you do every week, and try the first prompt related to it. You will feel the difference in under 15 minutes.

PART A — Foundations

Start every AI task with the right mindset, the right assistant, and a few clear words.

1. The AI Tool Mindset

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Do not ask “Which AI is best?” Ask these seven questions instead:

1. What exactly do I want done?
2. What kind of information does it need?
3. Does it need reasoning, search, files, images, or automation?
4. How important is it that the facts are correct?
5. Does it need up-to-date information?
6. Which tool is strongest for this specific job?
7. How will I check the result?

■ **Key idea**
Core principle: choose the tool based on the **task**, not the brand name.

■ **Try this**
List your three most repeated weekly tasks. Answer the seven questions for each. You now have your personal AI shortlist.

2. Core AI Assistants (the ones most people start with)

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Assistant	Great at	Best for	Friendly tip
ChatGPT	Writing, coding help, analysis, brainstorming	Learning, writing, structured work	Always double-check facts and code
Claude	Long documents, careful reasoning, writing quality	Big reports, complex instructions	Give it the full context it needs
Google Gemini	Google tools, images, everyday productivity	People already in Google Workspace	Check which features your plan includes
Microsoft Copilot	Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, Teams	Organisations on Microsoft 365	Check your organisation’s data rules first

Other helpful assistants (all free or freemium options exist): Grok (real-time feel), Meta AI (inside WhatsApp/Instagram), DeepSeek, Mistral, Qwen, Poe (many models in one place), You.com (search-focused).

3. Product vs Model vs API — simple explanation

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Product = the app you chat with (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini).
Model = the engine underneath (GPT, Claude, Gemini, Llama…).
API = the way developers plug the engine into their own software.

One engine can power many apps, and one app can sometimes let you switch engines.

Fast models are great for drafting, summaries and brainstorming. **Reasoning / thinking models** are better for maths, multi-step plans and hard analysis — but they are slower and cost more. You do not need the strongest model for every little task.

PART B — Research & Learning

Find reliable information faster and use AI as a patient personal tutor.

4. AI Search & Research

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Tool	Best for	Simple workflow	Avoid
Perplexity	Current web research with sources	Ask → see sources → compare → verify	Treating the summary as the final source
NotebookLM	Learning from your own PDFs & notes	Upload → ask grounded questions → check originals	Trusting answers you haven't checked
Google Scholar + AI	Finding academic papers	Find paper → open it → ask AI to extract → verify	Letting AI invent papers or results

■■ **Important**
Never cite anything you have not opened and confirmed yourself. AI can invent titles, authors and DOIs that look real.

Deep research flow: Define your question → Run deep research → Open the key sources → Check the claims → Note gaps → Write.

Helpful research tools: Elicit, Consensus, Scite, SciSpace, ResearchRabbit, Semantic Scholar, Scholarcy. Golden rule: AI speeds up discovery and organisation. **You** stay responsible for validity and conclusions.

5. AI as Your Personal Tutor

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

The best learning loop: Assess → Teach → Example → Practice → Test → Feedback → Retry.

Ask AI to: assess your current level, teach from the basics, use everyday analogies, ask Socratic questions, generate exercises, grade your answers, spot misconceptions, and gradually make things harder.

■ **Key idea**
Best tutor prompt
Teach me [TOPIC] from first principles. First assess my level with 5 questions. Then build a progressive lesson. Do not reveal answers before I attempt the exercises. After each attempt, tell me exactly what I misunderstood.

PART C — Prompt Engineering (how to ask well)

A clear request is the difference between a vague answer and something you can actually use.

6. The 10-part prompt model (you can start with just 4)

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Part	Question to answer
1. Role	What expertise is useful? (e.g. “You are a patient teacher”)
2. Objective	What must be achieved?
3. Context	What does the AI need to know?
4. Input	What information are you giving it?
5. Constraints	What limits apply? (length, tone, no jargon…)
6. Process	What stages should it follow?
7. Examples	What does a good answer look like?
8. Output	Exact format you want (bullets, table, email…)
9. Evaluation	How will you judge quality?
10. Safety	What must be verified or restricted?

■ **Try this**
Beginner shortcut: just use Role + Objective + Context + Output. That alone beats most one-line prompts.

Weak vs Strong

Weak	Strong
“Make me a presentation about AI.”	“Create a 10-slide presentation for first-year university students. Goal: explain generative AI. Each slide: one central idea, max 30 words, one suggested visual, speaker notes, and a transition to the next slide.”

7. Few-shot prompting & Prompt chaining

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Zero-shot = just ask. **Few-shot** = show 2–5 examples first so the AI sees the pattern.
Example: show a few “message → label” pairs, then give a new message to classify.

Prompt chaining (breaking big jobs into steps): Question → Scope → Evidence → Analysis → Outline → Draft → Critique → Final.
Complex tasks have many places to go wrong. Smaller steps make mistakes easier to catch.

8. Advanced techniques (when you are ready)

●●● **ADVANCED** – systems & deeper tools

Technique	When / how
Role prompting	Set expertise and viewpoint
Few-shot examples	Show good input–output pairs
Delimiters	Clearly mark instructions vs data
Structured output	Ask for JSON or a fixed table
Negative constraints	Say what must not appear
Self-critique	Ask the model to find flaws then revise
Chain of thought	Ask for step-by-step reasoning
Metaprompting	Ask the AI to improve your own prompt

9. When AI makes things up (hallucinations) & how to check

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

AI can invent citations, facts, quotes, numbers, or answers to questions that have no real answer — and sound very confident while doing it.

How to reduce them

- Give the source and say “use only this text”.
- Ask for quotes with page or section numbers.
- Allow “I don’t know”.
- Use web search for current facts.
- Verify numbers with a calculator or code.
- Cross-check with a second tool.

Simple quality checklist

- Accuracy — Are the claims correct?
- Relevance — Does it answer the actual task?
- Completeness — Are important requirements covered?
- Grounding — Are important claims supported by sources?
- Format — Did it follow the structure you asked for?
- Clarity — Can the intended audience understand it?
- Usability — Can you actually use the result?

PART D — Create: Writing, Slides & Media

Produce professional text, presentations, images, video and audio — even if you are not a designer.

10. AI Writing, Editing & Content

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Simple flow: Idea → Outline → Draft → Critique → Revision → Fact-check → Final.

Tool	Helpful for
Grammarly / LanguageTool	Grammar, tone, clarity
QuillBot / Wordtune	Paraphrasing and rewriting
DeepL	Translation and rewriting
Jasper / Copy.ai	Marketing copy (with review)

■ **Key idea**
Easy editing prompt
Edit the text below for clarity and concision. Keep my meaning, voice and technical terms. Do not add new facts. Show a list of the main changes, then the edited text.
[PASTE TEXT]

■■ **Important**
AI-text detectors are unreliable and can flag human writing. Follow your school or workplace policy on disclosure instead of relying on detector scores.

11. Presentations

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Tools many people love: Canva Magic Studio, Gamma, PowerPoint + Copilot, Google Slides + Gemini, Beautiful.ai, Pitch, Napkin AI (text → diagrams).

Good flow: Research → Storyline → Slide structure → Visuals → Human editing → Fact-check → Rehearse.

■ **Try this**
Never just say “Make me a presentation about AI.” Always tell it: audience, goal, number of slides, words per slide, what visuals you want, speaker notes, and transitions.

12. Images, Video & Audio

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Images — ChatGPT image tools, Canva AI, Adobe Firefly, Ideogram, Midjourney, Photoroom (background removal). A solid prompt formula: Subject + Environment + Composition + Style + Lighting + Camera + Mood + Constraints.

Video — Synthesia / HeyGen (avatar videos), CapCut, Descript, Opus Clip (long → short), Runway, Pika. Tip: generate short clips (5–10 s) and edit them together.

Audio — ElevenLabs / Murf (voices), Suno / Udio (songs), Otter / Fireflies / Fathom (meeting notes), Speechify, Krisp.

■■ **Important**
Never create deepfakes or clone a real person’s voice without clear permission. Check licensing before commercial use of generated images or audio.

PART E — Work Smarter

Meetings, everyday office tasks, business functions and light data work.

13. Productivity, Office & Meetings

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Most Microsoft 365 and Google Workspace apps now have built-in AI help for email, documents, spreadsheets and slides. Meeting tools (Otter, Fireflies, Fathom, Granola, Zoom AI, Teams Copilot) turn talk into notes, decisions and action items.

Simple meeting workflow

Before	During	After
agenda, objectives, questions, required docs	transcription, decisions, questions, action items	summary, owners, deadlines, follow-up email

■■ Important
Always get consent before recording or transcribing a meeting, and follow your organisation's rules and local law.

14. AI for Business (high-level map)

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Business area	How AI usually helps
Market research	Search + synthesis (Perplexity, deep research)
Customer support	Classify + draft replies (with human approval)
Sales	Lead research + personalised outreach drafts
Marketing	Ideas, content variants, basic analysis
Operations	SOP drafts + simple automation (Zapier, Make)
HR / Finance / Legal	First drafts only — always reviewed by a qualified person

■■ Important
High-impact decisions about employment, money, legal matters or health need human review by a qualified professional. AI drafts are starting points, not final advice.

15. Data Analysis & SQL (friendly entry)

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

You can ask tools like Julius AI, Excel Copilot or Gemini in Sheets to explore a spreadsheet in plain language. For more control, AI can write Python or SQL code that you then run and check.

■ Key idea
Safe data prompt
Here is the dataset description: [COLUMNS]. Question: [QUESTION]. First list assumptions and data-quality checks. Then provide code. Then explain what each result means and its limitations. Do not state any number unless it comes from the data or executed code.

PART F — Build: Code, Automation & Agents

These sections are for people who want to go further. You can skip them and still get huge value from the rest of the guide.

16. AI Coding Helpers

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Popular tools: GitHub Copilot, Cursor, Replit, Lovable / Bolt (prompt → web app), Claude Code, and others. Safe habit: always use version control, write tests, review every change, and never put secrets in the prompt.

■ **Key idea**
Debugging prompt
Error: [ERROR]
Code: [CODE]
Expected: [EXPECTED]
Actual: [ACTUAL]
What I already tried: [TRIED]
List the 3 most likely causes ranked by probability, how to confirm each, then give the smallest fix. Do not rewrite unrelated code.

17. Automation & Agents (simple view)

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Tools such as Zapier, Make, n8n or Power Automate let you connect apps so that "when this happens → do that". You can add an AI step in the middle (e.g. classify an email, draft a reply, then wait for your approval).

An **agent** is a system that can plan steps and use tools toward a goal. The more autonomy you give it, the more important it is to limit permissions, require human approval for irreversible actions, and keep logs.

18–20. Deeper topics (RAG, local AI, frameworks)

●●● **ADVANCED** – systems & deeper tools

RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) = the AI first finds relevant pieces of your own documents, then answers using them. Great for company manuals, course materials or private knowledge bases.

Local / open-source AI (Ollama, LM Studio, etc.) runs on your own computer — useful for privacy and offline work, but needs decent hardware.

Frameworks such as LangChain, LlamaIndex, CrewAI and MCP exist for people building custom systems. Most non-technical users never need them.

PART G — Stay Safe & Make AI Worth It

23. Security, Privacy & Ethics (for everyone)

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

> ■■ **Important**
> Never casually paste: passwords, API keys, confidential customer or patient data, private source code (if policy forbids it), or anything you would not want stored on a third-party server.

Safe habits: remove names and IDs, use placeholders, prefer local or enterprise tools for confidential material. Follow academic integrity rules, check copyright for commercial use, be aware of bias, and never create deepfakes without permission.

24. Verification & the productivity formula

●● **INTERMEDIATE** – templates & workflows

Match the amount of checking to the stakes:
• Low stakes → quick review
• Medium → source check + cross-check
• High → authoritative source + expert review

For code: generate → test → run → review.
For numbers: AI answer → calculate independently → confirm.

> ■ **Key idea**
> Productivity gain ≈ Task selection × Tool selection × Prompt quality × Workflow design × Verification.
> If any of these is near zero, the overall result suffers.

25. Turning AI into real time (and money) saved

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Strong fit: repetitive text work, first drafts you will review, summaries, classification, meeting follow-ups, formatting, customer replies you approve.
Weak fit: high-stakes decisions without review, tasks that need private facts the AI does not have, or anything where one error is costly and hard to catch.

Simple monthly estimate: (hours saved per week × 4 × value of one hour) – monthly tool cost.

26. Choosing tools & building a small personal stack

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

30-second decision tree:
1. Needs current information? → Use search / Perplexity-style tool.
2. Depends on my documents? → Use NotebookLM or document AI.
3. Needs code or data? → Coding / data environment + AI.
4. Needs image / video / audio? → Specialised creative tool.
5. Happens repeatedly? → Automate it.
If all answers are no, a general assistant is usually enough.

Do not install 30 tools. Build a small stack of seven parts: 1) one general assistant, 2) one research tool, 3) one coding helper (if needed), 4) one knowledge / document system, 5) one creative tool, 6) one automation platform, 7) verification habits.

27. Quick checklist & common mistakes

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Before you ask	**After the answer**	**Before automating**
• Exact objective?	• Correct?	• What if AI is wrong?
• Best tool?	• Complete?	• Human approval needed?
• Context needed?	• Followed instructions?	• Permissions limited?
• Safe to share?	• Invented anything?	• Actions reversible?
• Output format?	• Actually useful?	• Logging in place?

Common mistake	Easy fix
Vague prompt	State goal, audience, format and constraints
No context	Provide source text, examples and background
One giant request	Break it into a chain of smaller steps
Trusting the first answer	Ask for critique, then verify
Pasting secrets	Redact; use placeholders
Using one tool for everything	Match the tool to the task

28. Ready-to-use prompt library

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Summarise (Easy)

Summarise the text below for [AUDIENCE] in [N] bullet points, then list 3 open questions and any claims that need verification.

Email draft (Easy)

Write a [TONE] email to [RECIPIENT] about [TOPIC]. Goal: [GOAL]. Include a clear call to action and keep it under [N] words.

Study coach (Easy)

Quiz me on [TOPIC], one question at a time. Start easy, adapt difficulty, wait for my answer, explain mistakes, and finish with a list of weak areas.

Meeting notes (Intermediate)

From this transcript, extract: decisions, action items (owner and deadline), open questions and risks. Then write a 5-line summary and a follow-up email.

Decision matrix (Intermediate)

Compare [OPTIONS] using these criteria: [CRITERIA]. Weight each criterion, score each option, show the table, then explain the result and key uncertainties.

Devil’s advocate (Intermediate)

Here is my plan: [PLAN]. Act as a skeptical expert. List the 5 strongest objections, the assumptions most likely to be wrong, and what evidence would change your mind.

Prompt improver (Advanced)

Here is my prompt: [PROMPT]. Ask me up to 5 clarifying questions first. Then rewrite the prompt using Role, Objective, Context, Constraints and Output format, and explain what you changed.

29. Simple glossary

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Term	Plain-English meaning
LLM	Large language model — the text-trained engine behind most chat AIs
Prompt	The instruction or question you give the AI
Token	A small chunk of text the model reads or writes (roughly a word or part of a word)
Context window	How much text the model can look at in one go (prompt + files + reply)
Hallucination	When the AI invents something that sounds true but is not
Grounding	Tying answers to real sources you supplied or that were retrieved
Multimodal	Can handle text + images + audio + video together
Agent	A system that can plan steps and use tools toward a goal
RAG	Retrieve relevant documents first, then generate an answer from them
API	A way for software to call an AI model programmatically

30. Your 30-day action plan

● **EASY** – start here, no tech needed

Week	Focus
Week 1	Learn one assistant well: prompts, files, search, verification
Week 2	Add research and document tools; practise source checking
Week 3	Build one workflow: a prompt chain, a template, or a simple automation
Week 4	Evaluate with a simple rubric, write down what works, share your best prompt

My commitments

■ My primary assistant is: _____
■ My three target tasks are: _____
■ My baseline time (hours/week) is: _____
■ My first workflow to build is: _____
■ I will review my results on: _____
■ I will share my best prompt with: _____

> ■ **Key idea**
> Tools change fast. Use this sheet for categories and habits, and always confirm current details on each tool’s official site.

The one-page philosophy: AI is not the skill.

1. What to delegate 2. Which tool to use 3. How to specify the task 4. How to give context
5. How to structure the workflow 6. How to evaluate the output 7. When to verify
8. When not to use AI 9. How to automate responsibly

AI + Human judgement + Verification = Professional AI productivity

My workshop notes

Key ideas, prompts to try, questions to ask the instructor.

Thrive.

Institute of Wellness & Development

Use AI as a capability multiplier,
not a replacement for judgement.

Thank you for learning with us.

Workshop date: add here

Venue / online link: add here

Website · Email · Phone: add here